



Catherine the Great's spinel

△ Portrait of Tsar Nicholas II on his coronation day, wearing the Russian Imperial Crown with its spinel

Catherine the Great's "ruby" is the glittering showpiece of the Russian Imperial Crown. It is one of the "Seven Historic Stones", the rarest and most prized items in the royal collection of jewellery that was amassed by Peter the Great. This collection – now known as the Diamond Fund – was enlarged by later tsars, but always belonged to the State.

The "ruby" is actually a 398.72-carat red spinel, the second largest in the world. At the time, spinels were known as "balas rubies", taking their name from a famous mine in present-day Afghanistan. Russian envoy Nikolai Spafariy acquired the gemstone in China while conducting trade negotiations with the emperor in 1676. He reportedly paid "a very pretty price" of 2,672 rubles for it.

The spinel already had a colourful history.

According to legend, it was found in the 14th century by Chun Li, a Chinese mercenary in Turkic conqueror Timur's army. He found it in the mines of Badakhshan, where he had been exiled after stealing



Russian Imperial Crown, displaying the spinel mounted on a central arch, accompanied by 9,936 diamonds and 74 pearls

gems in Samarkand. Chun Li tried to present it to the emperor in the hope of winning a pardon, but was murdered by a greedy palace guard who, in turn, was executed when his crime was discovered.

Catherine the Great commissioned the magnificent Imperial Crown for her 1762 coronation. It was fashioned by the court jeweller, Jérémie Pauzié, who removed the spinel from an earlier crown and added other jewels from the royal collection. Worn by Catherine's successors, the crown was concealed from view after the Revolution.

The spinel must have been an exceedingly unlucky stone

Emperor Paul I of Russia, Catherine's only son, wearing the crown c.1800

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Key dates

1676–1990s

